

Civic Activation Measure (CAM) — Candidate Item Pool v0.1

Draft for review by Marc Pierson and Kerry Turner. Not yet fielded. All item numbering is provisional; Winsteps will decide what survives.

Construct definition (working)

Civic activation: the belief, knowledge, confidence, and practiced capacity a person needs to participate in decisions affecting their neighborhood — up to and including sustaining working relationships through disagreement, defeat, and tedium.

Referent throughout: "my neighborhood." Respondents define it themselves; a preamble may optionally anchor it (~the area you could walk across, the few thousand people nearest you).

Response scale

Uniform 4-point: Strongly Disagree / Disagree / Agree / Strongly Agree. No neutral midpoint. Optional N/A only where an item presupposes an opportunity the respondent may never have had (flagged Ø below).

All items are phrased as present-tense dispositions or standing states, not time-bounded event reports, so one rating scale fits every item.

Candidate items

Ordered by intended difficulty, easy end first. The empirical hierarchy will differ; that is the point.

Stratum 1 — Believing it matters (intended easy end)

1. Decisions made in my neighborhood affect my daily life.
2. What happens in my neighborhood is partly my responsibility.
3. My participation in neighborhood decisions can make a difference.
4. Ordinary residents can change how things are done here.
5. When something in my neighborhood bothers me, I assume something can be done about it.
6. I know the names of several of my neighbors.
7. I pay attention to what is happening in my neighborhood.

Stratum 2 — Knowing and being confident (lower middle)

8. I know where to find out what is being decided in my neighborhood.
9. I know who makes decisions about my street and neighborhood.
10. I know how to contact the people who represent my neighborhood.

11. I know how to find the agenda for a public meeting that affects my neighborhood.
12. I can tell the difference between a decision that is already made and one that is still open.
13. I could explain to a neighbor how a local decision gets made.
14. I am confident I could speak at a public meeting if I needed to.
15. I know which neighborhood matters I can influence and which I cannot.
16. I can follow a discussion of a local budget well enough to have an opinion.
17. I know how to bring a concern to the right person or body instead of the wrong one.

Stratum 3 — Taking part (upper middle)

18. I ask my neighbors for help when I need it.
19. I offer help to neighbors without being asked.
20. I talk with neighbors about issues that affect us.
21. I attend meetings where neighborhood decisions are discussed. ☐
22. I speak up in meetings when I have something to say. ☐
23. I contact officials about neighborhood issues when they arise.
24. I volunteer time to groups working in my neighborhood.
25. I help organize neighborhood activities or gatherings.
26. When I disagree with a proposal, I say so in the meeting rather than only complaining afterward. ☐
27. I bring neighbors who are not yet involved into neighborhood activities.
28. I take on tasks between meetings, not just opinions during them. ☐

Stratum 4 — Staying woven through conflict (intended hard end)

29. I keep participating even when meetings are slow or boring.
30. I seek out neighbors who disagree with me to understand their reasons.
31. I can state the strongest version of a position I disagree with.
32. I stay in the room when a discussion turns against me. ☐
33. I can work productively with a neighbor I personally dislike.
34. After a proposal of mine is voted down, I keep working with the people who voted against it. ☐
35. I have publicly changed my position when someone persuaded me. ☐
36. I help carry out group decisions I argued against. ☐
37. When a group decision goes badly, I help fix it rather than saying "I told you so." ☐
38. I help groups turn a conflict into a proposal better than either side started with. ☐
39. I keep showing up after the group has disappointed me. ☐
40. I take responsibility for outcomes of decisions I shared in, even ones I opposed. ☐

Reserve items (possible gap-fillers, second wave)

- 41. I read or listen to local news about my area.
- 42. I could name one decision made in my neighborhood in the past year.
- 43. I feel comfortable knocking on a neighbor's door.
- 44. I trust my neighbors to deal fairly with me.
- 45. I would host a neighborhood conversation in my home.
- 46. I have asked a group to slow down so quieter people could be heard. ☐
- 47. I can disagree with someone in a meeting and greet them warmly the next day. ☐
- 48. I would rather share in a decision I partly dislike than have my way imposed.

Fielding protocol

- Sample: 50–150 respondents across at least three distinct Whatcom contexts (e.g., an active neighborhood association, a church or service club, a street with no organized structure). Deliberately include the uninvolved; the easy end cannot calibrate without them.
- Administration: paper or web, 5–10 minutes, anonymous, with three or four demographic fields at most (rough age band, years at current address, whether they belong to any local group).
- Analysis: Winsteps, Andrich rating scale model. First questions to the output, in order: 1. Do the items define one variable? (dimensionality, fit statistics) 2. What is the empirical difficulty order, and does it tell a coherent developmental story? 3. Where are the gaps on the yardstick? 4. Does the stick reach both ends — especially the hard end? Person-item targeting map is the honesty check. 5. Category function: are all four response categories being used, in order?
- Misfitting items are information, not failures: each one teaches something about the construct's edges.

Governance (non-negotiable, learned the hard way)

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